

The social sciences have a repertoire of theoretical and methodological traditions that defined the role and place of social sciences in the world first and foremost. Like the natural sciences, social science is concerned with knowledge production. Knowledge that would help advance the understanding of humans and reach and maximize this human potential. But unlike the natural sciences, it is concentrated on uncovering the ontological and epistemological origins of knowledge. Since the inception of the field of social sciences, much work has been done in terms of theoretical and methodological traditions that govern the different disciplines, whether core, extension, or borderline. This differentiates social sciences from natural ones because actors are allowed to think and interpret the world democratically and creatively. At this point in time, there have been five major paradigms that guide research in the social sciences. They are built on the premise of whether reality is discovered or created. These are positivism, post-positivism, critical realism, contextualism, and social constructionism.

One of the widely used paradigms in research, whether natural or social, is positivism. Positivism argues that reality exists free from the mind, and there is a single truth. In other words, universal, objective knowledge is generated through a thorough analysis of data mustered from the environment. Positivism proposes that knowledge is discovered by following a rigorous and clearly defined procedure (Galano, 2021). Meanwhile, post-positivism was introduced to address the disparity between academic research and the human experience. It argues that, indeed, there is a single truth. However, the truth is not neutral in the sense that it is influenced by the context of the researcher and the researched (Galano, 2021). Veering away from the single truth proposition and recognizing the valuable effect of researcher position, contextualism believes that knowledge emerges and is influenced by the context and positions of the researchers. It is local, situation-specific, and provisional. Thus, acknowledges that truths may be true in certain circumstances (Galano, 2021). Similarly, critical realism argues that knowledge is shaped by the language, culture, and history of the researchers. In other words, knowledge is historically and culturally situated. Hence, disapproves that knowledge is universal and objective (Galano, 2021). Meanwhile, on the opposite end of the spectrum, where knowledge is believed to be co-constructed, social constructionism acknowledges how language, culture, and history affect the means for knowledge production. That it forwards that there is no truth to be discovered but rather to be created. Additionally, it argues that reality is not separated from the way humans understand it. In short, we, humans give meaning to our experiences (Galano, 2021). These are the five major methodological traditions that govern the way how we generate knowledge, or in this case, create knowledge. Additionally, it is important to mention that these do not exist as discrete categories, but rather on a continuum.

## **Theoretical Roots**

Now that we know where knowledge is found, how did it all start? Based on the arguments presented in the works of Appadurai, Santos, and Escobar, it can be concluded that the theoretical roots of these methods were the natural sciences. Compared to the natural sciences, the social sciences were a relatively new field of study, which when we trace back, brings us to the 19th century. We owe so much of the world and society today to the methods, theories, and frameworks of natural sciences. If it were not for these, we would have not realized

the extension of human development and understand our rich human history. From the study of the celestial bodies up to the study of plants, it follows a strictly defined set of procedures. This is what is to be understood as “real” science. However, the introduction of social sciences was unwelcomed, if not rejected by academic communities at first. The methods, frameworks, and theories of the various disciplines of the social sciences were deemed peculiar and non-science. This crisis has revolutionized the study of society in a way it patterned its ways similar to the works of the natural sciences. This explains why positivism, or the single truth proposition is on one end of the pole of the paradigm spectrum. It is the one reason why the social sciences are legitimized and acknowledged as “real” science.

From another perspective, the roots of the methods of social sciences can also be attributed to the theory of essentialism. Essentialist views argue that the world is made up of discrete categories with a certain form, use, and essence. And the field of science is no exception. Many scholarly communities believed that science is demarcated between the natural and social sciences. They are binary branches that constitute the field of science. However, as pointed out by Escobar (2007), this binarism of the world into male and female, earth and heaven, body and soul, subject and object, natural and social, has forgotten to define and articulate the blurred boundaries. This caused the existence of the spectrum of paradigms in the social sciences. To some extent, this has leveled the playing field by introducing new methods, theories, and frameworks that enrich and advance the knowledge production capacity of social sciences. These changes will be discussed shortly.

### **Changes in Methods, Theories, and Concepts**

The methods, frameworks, and theories of social sciences are not fixed. They developed in accordance with the political, social, and economic milieu of the specific time and space they were situated in. The theories, concepts, and debates that were raised during pre-World War 2 were different from the post-War era. Likewise, the theories and debates during the pre-globalization era were different from the time of globalization itself. These changes had brought more epistemological and ontological underpinnings for the social sciences.

As mentioned above, the dissatisfaction with essentialist and positivist views of the world has triggered a revolution in the paradigm science will uphold and practice through research. However, aside from the ones mentioned earlier such as contextualism, social constructionism, and critical realism, other paradigms were introduced as a consequence of various political, social, and economic events, particularly the era of globalization. Some examples of these paradigms are feminism, phenomenology, intersectionality, and indigenization.

According to Escobar (2007), feminism was introduced to research around the 1980s. This was also a time where women are fighting for their rights in terms of self-determination, career, and suffrage. The introduction of feminist views in research was a breakthrough to a typically male-dominated field. Since much of the actors and producers of knowledge were generated from the perspective of men, the creation of a new field allowed to have variegated views on matters which are nuanced and dependent on the positions (e.g., gender) of the researcher. Meanwhile, at the zenith of modernism, phenomenology was introduced (Escobar,

2007). Phenomenology aims to explain a phenomenon from the first-person point of view. It seeks to understand a phenomenon based on the meanings attached to it by the people who experienced it. In other words, it acknowledges the intersubjective nature of reality, as opposed to the single truth proposition of the epoch of modernism. Thus, an argument to the dualist nature of essentialism.

On the other hand, one issue that is still not addressed in the field of research is replicability. With numerous volumes of research done, mostly by Western academicians, there exist a gap between knowledge produced and practiced. One probable reason for this as explained by Appadurai (2000), Santos (2007), and Escobar (2007) is the dominant culture of Western scholars. Most repositories, if not all, are accessed and dominated by the works of scholars from academic institutions like the United States (Appadurai, 2000). This caused an unequal distribution and contribution of knowledge from esteemed and capable non-Western scholars. This had become a vehicle for hegemony to the countries with the least and weakest scholarship. In response, cross-cultural studies were introduced through the indigenization movement. The indigenization movement is committed to offering an alternative perspective of analysis on a matter. It presents that knowledge is best explained and understood when the researcher's position agrees with the contexts of its production. One example is Sikolohiyang Pilipino. Filipino Psychology was only introduced during the 1970s – a time where there is great turmoil in the Philippines. To make sense of this, Kapwa theory by Virgilio Enriquez includes the values of Katarungan (justice), Kapayaan (peace), and Karangalan (dignity) and explained the anti-fascist era in a way that Filipinos would understand best because it was analyzed using their language, situation, and culture.

Furthermore, another consequence of this replication crisis was the disparity in the characteristics of participants. Much knowledge produced that was being generalized to the whole population was collected from privileged identities. What do I mean by privileged identities are the social categories favored by the system like White (race/ethnicity), middle-class (class), educated (socioeconomic status), male (gender) individuals. This is where the methodological tradition of intersectionality was introduced. Intersectionality recognizes that social realities are shaped by the identities of the researchers and the researched. To provide a platform and give voice to the oppressed and marginalized identities (e.g., LGBTQIA, black, non-educated), the framework of intersectionality utilizes these identities as variables to analyze and develop meanings of the experiences of these individuals. In this way, it permits more room to develop findings and recommendations which are not only apt to policymakers, but also the construction and understanding of their realities (Appadurai, 2000).

With all that said, I assume at this juncture of the paper, that the theoretical and methodological traditions of social sciences transcended its original mission of mimicking natural science. I believe that it is now oriented in achieving social justice through cognitive justice.

## Cognitive Justice in Social Sciences

In all three articles, they mentioned that methods, frameworks, and theories of the sciences are developed by Western thinkers. The science we know, and practice is Western science, and this allowed them to dominate and control political and economic policies internationally. But with everything I have mentioned above, we are moving towards cognitive justice. Cognitive justice argues that there is a need to look for alternative paradigms for modern science to advance consistently and progressively. A dialogue between academic communities is warranted to allow a more sustainable, equitable, and democratic science. Feminism, intersectionality, indigenization, and phenomenology are clear examples that scientific research practice vis-à-vis reality is multifaceted and complex. It should not be looked at from the same point of view of the powerful and the privileged.

At this point, we have seen how relevant cognitive justice is in closing the gap in research, resolving the replicability crisis, and underrepresentation and misrepresentation. The numerous dissatisfaction and crises that challenged modern science are clear indicators that Western science is not universal science. Therefore, it is significant to acknowledge as real science the science in the cultures and traditions of non-Western countries. It is only in this way we can truly achieve a scientific tradition that forwards justice for all.

### References:

Galano, C., P. (2021, March 10). Introduction to field and qualitative research [PPT].

<https://classroom.google.com/u/3/w/MjY3Mjk2NzkyODk2/t/all>

Appadurai, A. (2000). "Grassroots Globalization and the Research Imagination."

Public Culture 12 (1).

Escobar, A. (2007). Actors, Networks, and New Knowledge Producers: Social Movements and the Paradigmatic Transition in the Sciences." In Santos 2007b, 273-294.

Santos, B. (Ed.). (2008). Another Knowledge Is Possible: Beyond Northern Epistemologies.

London

Verso (Ed.) (2007b). Cognitive Justice in a Global World: Prudent Knowledge for a Decent Life.

Lanham, MD: Lexington Books